

BlueHat v17 || Dangerous Contents

BlueHat v17 || Dangerous Contents - BlueHat Security Conference, Slideshare.

- Published: 2017-12-09
- Original: <https://www.slideshare.net/slideshow/dangerous-contents-securing-net-deserialization/83686352>
- Preserved from: <https://www.slideshare.net/slideshow/dangerous-contents-securing-net-deserialization/83686352> (preserved-copy) on 2026-08-04
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Dangerous Contents

Securing .NET Deserialization
Jonathan Borch - Microsoft Corporation

What this talk is about

- How misuse of serialization in .NET can lead to RCE vulnerabilities.
- How to prevent those vulnerabilities
- Advice for specific serialization APIs
- How to scan for serialization vulnerabilities

Background - Serialization

Serialization – what is it?

- Serialization is a technique for packaging program data into a more portable or storable form.
 - Data structures are converted into streams or strings so that they can be backed up or sent elsewhere.
- Serialization is typically used with the goal of restoring the original data structures at some later time, possibly somewhere else.



Serialization – how is it used?

Common use cases for serialization include:

- **Transferring data** between clients and servers.
- **Backing up objects** to a database.
- **Creating equivalence** between objects in different environments (JSON serialization, XML serialization).

How serialization can be exploited

How can serialization be dangerous?

- Many serialization API's package type information into the stream. This allows the stream to contain types that weren't predicted at design time.
- Many scenarios where serialization is used involve the stream coming from an untrusted party.
- This means an attacker can package objects into the stream that the application doesn't expect.

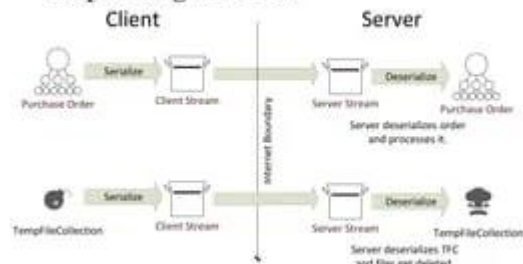
What's the danger in unpacking unexpected types?

- An application can only deserialize types that come from either the framework or other modules it loads. An attacker can't just define a malicious type and have an application deserialize it.
- But many types built into the .NET framework have code that will run just because they were instantiated:
 - Constructors
 - OnDeserialize handlers
 - Setters
 - Destructors
- It's possible to leverage these methods in combination to build "gadgets" that allow arbitrary code execution.

Simple serialization exploit – TempFileCollection via BinaryFormatter

- .Net has a class called "TempFileCollection". It's intended to manage a collection of temporary files that it deletes when it's garbage collected.
- This class is serializable, so it can be serialized to and deserialized from a stream with BinaryFormatter.
- If an attacker has access to a stream that will be deserialized on a server using BinaryFormatter they can populate a TempFileCollection object with a list of files and then serialize it into the stream.
- When the server deserializes the stream, it creates the same TempFileCollection object. When this object is garbage collected, it will delete the list of files the attacker specified from the server.

Exploiting a server



Better attacks exist

- This is not the only way to exploit serialization, or even the best way.
- This is just an exploit that's relatively straightforward to explain.
- James Forshaw has demonstrated a full HCE gadget chain that's much more powerful, but is somewhat harder to explain in a half hour talk. See ["Exploiting .Net Managed HCOM"](#).

Why is this a problem?

- Deserialization of untrusted streams is an unfortunately common antipattern.
- This vulnerability used to be present in several Microsoft products. Those issues should be fixed now. If you find one, please let us know.
- It's very easy to find services on the Internet with this vulnerability. Microsoft has reached out in some cases where we've become aware of this issue, but it's not practical for us to try to find every vulnerable instance.
- Since exploits of this type of vulnerability lead to remote code execution, the potential impact is very high.

Why not fix the dangerous types?

- .NET has hundreds of thousands of types. A large number of those are potentially dangerous.
- Many of the "vulnerable" types are dangerous to deserialize because of the functionality they provide. "Fixing" them would require breaking that functionality, and hence can't be done without at minimum breaking framework compatibility.
- .NET (along with most frameworks) isn't designed to be safe in the case where a malicious user can generate arbitrary objects.
- The only solution to .NET deserialization vulnerabilities is for application developers to avoid using deserialization insecurely.

"But I don't use BinaryFormatter"

- Are you sure? Lots of APIs use BinaryFormatter under the hood:
 - Anything that reads .res files
 - ASP.NET ViewState (more on this later)
 - Various other "formatter" APIs, like ObjectStateFormatter and LoBFormatter
 - A longer list can be found at the end of this deck and in the handbook.
- Even serializers that don't use BinaryFormatter can be vulnerable...

- By default, `JavaScriptSerializer` does not serialize or deserialize type information.
 - But it will do so if `JavaScriptTypeResolver` is provided to the constructor, particularly if the built-in `JavaScriptTypeResolver` class is used.
- `JavaScriptSerializer` with `SimpleTypeResolver` will only create instances of objects with public parameterless constructors – this means the exploit I demonstrated for `BinaryFormatter` won't work.
- `JavaScriptSerializer` will only assign values to properties of objects.
- But unlike `BinaryFormatter`, `JavaScriptSerializer` + `SimpleTypeResolver` will deserialize not only as serializable, it will also call constructors and setters for properties it sets.

A simple JavaScriptSerializer exploit

[illegible]

Exploiting JSON .NET

- ```
string json = @"{
 ""Type"": ""System.Security.Principal.WindowsIdentity, mscorlib,
 Version=4.0.0.0, Culture=en-us, PublicKeyToken=b77a5c561934e089"", ""System.Security.ClaimsIdentity
 .bootstrapContext"": ""AIAAAAI/////""};
```

- Base64-encoded
- BinaryFormatter payload

- Templated serializer - requires that you provide an expected type
- Includes type information in stream for members of the root type.
- Decides whether or not to create objects based on whether `expectedType.IsAssignableFrom(providerType)`
- This check is always true if the expected type is something like `Object` - generic types like this acts like wildcards that will allow any type.
- This means that any type graph that can contain a generic member like `Object` can be exploited in the same way as `JavaScriptSerializer`. You can get to `Object` from a large number of types in .NET
- For example: `System.Xml.Linq.XElement` has a `TargetSite` property which has an `Attributes` parameter which can be assigned a `MethodInfo` object. `MethodInfo` has a `StaticParameter` property which has a `DefaultValue` property of type `Object`.

This type of exploit used to work:

- I contacted the maintainers of ServiceStack.Test through MSVN and they updated their API to only observe the above listed types.

- # How to Prevent Deserialization Vulnerabilities

1. Users can modify a stream that will be deserialized.
2. Type information is parsed from the stream.
3. The set of types that can be generated is not tightly constrained.

- The simplest way to keep serialization safe is to only deserialize streams you serialized in the first place.
- If the stream never leaves your back-end server, it might be safe. Make sure there isn't a different vulnerability that allows the stream to be modified.

■ An HMAC is very useful here:

- Can be used to prevent users from modifying a stream you're having them hold onto in a cookie or form data.
- Can also act as a second layer of defense if you deserialize streams stored in a back-end database. HMAC injection may allow an attacker to modify the stream, but an HMAC mismatch would almost certainly be noticeable.

- Some serializers don't parse type information from the stream. These are generally safe to use, even in untrusted streams.
  - `JavaScriptSerializer` without a `JavaScriptTypeResolver` is safe because it doesn't resolve types.
  - `JSON.NET` with `TypeNameHandling` set to "None" is safe.
  - `DataContractSerializer` and `XmlSerializer` are also safe.
- Note that all of these serializers become unsafe if you take other measures to let the stream contain type information. This includes letting the stream pick the type used for a templated deserialization.

## Constraining allowed types

- Sometimes you may want a user-controlled deserialized stream to contain type information. It's possible to make this safe.
- If you restrict the allowed types to a safe allow-list, exploit should not be possible.
- Determining which types are safe is quite difficult, and this approach is **not recommended** unless necessary.
- There are many types that might allow non-RCE exploits if they are deserialized from untrusted data. Denial of service is especially common.
- As an example, the `System.Collections.HashTable` class is **not** safe to deserialize from an untrusted stream – the stream can specify the size of the internal “bucket” array and cause an out of memory condition.

## Constraining Allowed Types: The Wrong Way

### Don't do this:

```
MyType thing =
(MyType)myBinaryFormatter.Deserialize(untrustedStream);
```

Casting the result of a deserialization does nothing to improve security.

By the time an exception is thrown due to a failed typecast, most exploits have already done whatever they're going to do.

## Constraining Allowed Types: The *sort of* ok way

- The “Right Way” to constrain what types may be instantiated during deserialization is with a **allow list** enforced by a `SerializationBinder`.
- `BinaryFormatter`, the `JSON.NET` serializer, and a few others allow a `SerializationBinder` to be used to constrain which types can be created.
- To make a secure `SerializationBinder`, make a subclass of the `SerializationBinder` class that overrides the `BindToType` method and throws an exception if it encounters an unexpected type.

## SerializationBinder Tips

- Your binder will be called for **every** type, even the types of members of your expected types. You must allow-list all of them. It can help to make an initial version that just logs encountered types.
- **Don't use `IsAssignableFrom`** – this leads to the type of vulnerability I found in `ServiceStack.Text`.
- **Don't return null for unexpected types** – this makes some serializers fall back to a default binder, allowing exploits.
- **Don't use reflection to look up types** – That is to say, don't do this:

```
Assembly.Load(assemblyName).GetType(typeName);
```

Reflection is slow, and a malicious user can DoS your application by forcing it to spend memory and time loading irrelevant assemblies.

## SerializationBinder Example

```
sealed class AllowListSerializationBinder : ISerializationBinder {
 static readonly string[] types = allowedTypes = new List<Type>() {
 typeof(string), typeof(MyType), typeof(MyType2)};
 }

 public override Type BindToType(string assemblyName, string typeName) {
 foreach (Type type in types) {
 if (type.IsAssignableFrom(Type.GetType(typeName))) {
 return type; // safe!
 }
 }
 throw new ArgumentException($"Not allowed type {typeName}");
 }
}

myBinaryFormatter.Binder = new AllowListSerializationBinder();
```

# Advice for specific serialization API's

## Advice for BinaryFormatter

- Never use `BinaryFormatter` to deserialize an untrusted stream without a binder.
- A `SerializationBinder` is difficult to implement well, so if you're currently using `BinaryFormatter` to deserialize an untrusted stream, consider doing one of the following first:
  - Prevent users from modifying streams by keep them server-side or by using an HMAC.
  - Consider using a safer serializer, like `DataContractSerializer` or `XmlSerializer`.

## Advice for ASP .Net ViewState

- ASP .NET applications can use the `ViewState` object to store session data client-side.
- The `ViewState` is a collection of .Net objects which are serialized using `BinaryFormatter` and stored in the form data for a page. The server deserializes this data each time a request is made that contains a `ViewState` field.
- `ViewState` uses an HMAC to prevent any tampering of this data that might allow for an RCE exploit, but this HMAC is generated using a server's **machinekey** as a secret.
- It's important to ensure that malicious users cannot discover or guess the machinekey as this can allow an attack against the server-side deserialization.

## Advice for JSON .NET

- Never set `TypeNameHandling` to any value other than `"None"` on any object that has the property. Even `"Objects"` is unsafe.
- If you must use `TypeNameHandling` with a different value, use a `SerializationBinder` to prevent the deserialization of unexpected types.
- `SerializationBinders` for JSON .NET can be constructed identically to the ones for `BinaryFormatter`, but they should implement the `ISerializationBinder` interface instead of subclassing `SerializationBinder`.
- Like `BinaryFormatter` `SerializationBinders`, these should throw an exception if an unexpected type is encountered.

## Advice for JavaScriptSerializer

- Don't use `SimpleTypeResolver` with `JavaScriptSerializer` - this is essentially never safe.
- Don't add logic to allow the serialized stream to pick the class used to template the deserialization operation.

## Advice for ServiceStack.Text

- Make sure that any stream deserialized using ServiceStack.Text cannot be modified by users.
- If you choose to use ServiceStack.Text with a user-modifiable stream, avoid using a template type that can contain an "Object" in its member graph.

# Scanning for serialization vulnerabilities

## Static analysis – Scan your source

- Serialization vulnerabilities are dangerous enough that it's worth reviewing any place you use a dangerous deserialization API. Searching your code for calls to dangerous methods is a good place to start. There's a list at the end of this doc.
- If you use an unsafe serializer on untrusted data without a binder, it's a vulnerability you should fix immediately.
- Some serializers are safe by default but can be put into an "unsafe mode" by setting certain properties. If you see either of the following strings in your code, be very suspicious:
  - TypeNameHandling
  - SingleTypeResolver

## Dynamic Analysis

- Some common antipatterns can be identified just by looking at web traffic logs.
- Base-64 encoded binary formatter streams always begin with the sequence `AAEAAAD` – this string is a very significant indicator of deserialization RCE.
  - For raw HTTP traffic, it may be useful to search for the raw-encoded version of this sequence.
- Similarly, the presence of `!type` or `__type` can indicate either a JSON.NET, JavaScriptSerializer, or ServiceStack.Text vulnerability.

## Questions?

1. System.Runtime.Serialization.Formatters.Binary.BinaryFormatter –

Deserialize, UnsafeDeserialize, UnsafeDeserializeMethodResponse

1. System.Runtime.Serialization.Formatters.Soap.SoapFormatter – Deserialize

2. System.Web.UI.ObjectStateFormatter- Deserialize

3. System.Runtime.Serialization.NetDataContractSerializer – Deserialize,

ReadObject

1. System.Web.UI.LosFormatter – Deserialize

2. System.Workflow.ComponentModel.Activity – Load

3. SoapServerFormatterSinkProvider, SoapClientFormatterSinkProvider,

BinaryServerFormatterSinkProvider, BinaryClientFormatterSinkProvider,

SoapClientFormatterSink, SoapServerFormatterSink, BinaryClientFormatterSink,

BinaryServerFormatterSink – unsafe if used across an insecure channel or if used to talk to an untrusted party](<https://image.slidesharecdn.com/securingdotnetdeserialization-bluehat-updated4-171209010051/85/BlueHat-v17-Dangerous-Contents-Securing-Net-Deserialization-40-320.jpg>)

! [Partial List of unsafe API's (2)

1. System.Resource.ResourceReader – unsafe if used to read an untrusted resource string or stream

1. Microsoft.Web.Design.Remote.ProxyObject – DecodeValue, DecodeSerializedObject

1. System.Web.Script.Serialization.JavaScriptSerializer – unsafe if used to deserialize an untrusted stream with a JavaScriptTypeResolver set

1. Newtonsoft / JSON.Net JsonSerializer – unsafe if the TypeNameHandling property is set to any value other than “None”

1. ServiceStack.Text – unsafe if used to deserialize an object whose membership graph can contain a member of type “Object”]

(<https://image.slidesharecdn.com/securingdotnetdeserialization-bluehat-updated4-171209010051/85/BlueHat-v17-Dangerous-Contents-Securing-Net-Deserialization-41-320.jpg>)